

$z = -2$ (weak regime)

PRIVATE BRIEFING

BOTTOM LINE: Signs of institutional erosion are accumulating faster than the regime can manage them.
ATMOSPHERE: Coordination is happening in plain sight – meetings, signals, preparations that would have been unthinkable a month ago.

EVIDENCE:

- [Elite Cohesion] senior figures are giving interviews that subtly distance themselves from the leader's recent decisions
- [Security Forces] reports of soldiers fraternizing with civilians more than usual at checkpoints (overwhelming convergence – every channel telling the same story independently)
- [Money And Logistics] customs and trade are flowing normally at the borders – no unusual delays or inspections (overwhelming convergence – every channel telling the same story independently)
- [Street Mood] jokes about the regime are being told openly in places where that would have been unthinkable
- [Information Control] leaked documents are circulating faster than the regime can discredit them (overwhelming convergence – every channel telling the same story independently)
- [Personal Observations] your cousin in the army hasn't called in two weeks – unusual for someone who calls every Sunday (near-unanimous confirmation from every reliable source)
- [Diplomatic Signals] international shipping companies have reclassified the country as higher-risk for cargo insurance – the trend cooling off, though not yet cold
- [Institutional Functioning] municipal services – garbage collection, water, permits – have become erratic in the capital

UNCERTAINTIES:

- Whether any of the apparent weakness is being deliberately staged to flush out opponents.
- How much of the disarray is structural versus a temporary response to a specific crisis.

$z = 0$ (ambiguous)

PRIVATE BRIEFING

BOTTOM LINE: The situation could tip either way – there are credible signals pointing in both directions.
ATMOSPHERE: There's a palpable sense that a critical mass is forming, even if nobody can count the numbers yet.

EVIDENCE:

- [Elite Cohesion] elites are publicly unified but privately positioning themselves for multiple outcomes (a couple of contacts mentioning it independently)
- [Security Forces] the security forces are maintaining presence but seem to be conserving resources rather than demonstrating strength (a couple of contacts mentioning it independently)
- [Money And Logistics] economic indicators are mixed – retail spending is down but construction permits are up
- [Street Mood] people are frustrated but fatalistic – complaining more, but not in a way that suggests action
- [Information Control] the regime is still shaping the narrative but has lost the initiative – they're responding to events rather than framing them
- [Personal Observations] a well-connected friend said 'it could go either way' and seemed genuinely unsure (a couple of contacts mentioning it independently)
- [Diplomatic Signals] foreign embassies are maintaining full operations but have updated contingency plans – standard prudence or genuine concern
- [Institutional Functioning] the system is creaking but not collapsing – people are working around the bottlenecks rather than through them (a couple of contacts mentioning it independently)

UNCERTAINTIES:

- Whether the population's quiescence reflects genuine acceptance or merely the absence of a triggering event.
- Whether the stability you're seeing is structural or just a temporary equilibrium that could shift quickly.

$z = +2$ (strong regime)

PRIVATE BRIEFING

BOTTOM LINE: Current indicators point to maintained control, with internal challenges being managed rather than spiraling.
ATMOSPHERE: People are aware of each other's frustrations but nobody is naming them directly. It's communication through omission.

EVIDENCE:

- [Elite Cohesion] the regime successfully managed a minor scandal by presenting a unified response within hours
- [Security Forces] security checkpoints have been reduced, suggesting confidence rather than siege mentality (overwhelming convergence – every channel telling the same story independently)
- [Money And Logistics] customs and trade are flowing normally at the borders – no unusual delays or inspections (overwhelming convergence – every channel telling the same story independently)
- [Street Mood] people complain but do it like people who expect tomorrow to look much like today
- [Information Control] social media monitoring appears sophisticated and well-resourced (overwhelming convergence – every channel telling the same story independently)
- [Personal Observations] your cousin in the army hasn't called in two weeks – unusual for someone who calls every Sunday (near-unanimous confirmation from every reliable source)
- [Diplomatic Signals] foreign students continue to enroll at local universities – their embassies haven't advised them to leave – the trend moving with a momentum that would be hard to reverse
- [Institutional Functioning] municipal services are running smoothly – a mundane but reliable indicator of institutional health

UNCERTAINTIES:

- Whether the regime's strength is being accurately perceived by potential challengers – overestimation could be self-fulfilling.
- If unrest flares, the response capacity seems intact – though no system is invulnerable to surprises.